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THE DRY TALENT PIPELINE

GET THIS straight. Cricket isn't about making money. It's about making players. It's about making winners. It's about building assets. And assets need investments. You can't just keep hoping and praying that God will keep churning out talent. Yes, He has been very kind to Pakistan cricket and we have more raw and exciting talent, pound for pound, than any other country. Everybody who knows or plays cricket admits this. But the PCB is really pushing its luck with this 'raw talent will always rise' narrative.

That's just one diagnosis for one of the several ailments the PCB suffers from. As I mentioned earlier, a quick-fix prognosis is to get an outsider to head the board. Someone who can give the fat cats the stick. Someone who can overhaul the system. We need a systemic as well as a structural shake-up. We need an oil change. We need new leadership.

There is no consistency in the board's functioning. The entire system changes when the chairman changes. Can you believe it? It's as if we are a political party or something, not a cricket administration.Worse is the politics: in 2015–16, we had two chairmen – one semi-retired and one semi-appointed – so, essentially, we had two systems!

Look at the chairpersons of boards in other cricketing countries. They don't behave like selectors. They behave like grand old PR (public relations) men, diplomats, lobbyists even, to keep relations with other cricket boards smooth and intact. We need a solid, respectable chairman, who doesn't meddle with the inner trappings of team selection. We probably need a *gora* CEO under him, to run the system. And we need a free and independent selection committee. You don't just pick a kid for nationals after watching him score a 50 in a local game. Or because you saw a clip of his innings on social media. Yes, you can pluck bowlers while they're young. But not batsmen. Batsmen have to weather the storms of local cricket before they can sail on the big international seas. That's why Australia rotates bowlers aggressively, but not its batsmen. Batsmen are long-term investments. They have to be grown, not plucked.

India has done better than us in this regard. One, they invest their money back in the game